

Italian Heritage in the Bronx: The Bronx Italian American History Initiative [B2]

L'immigrazione italiana del secondo dopoguerra ha trasformato molte città degli Stati Uniti. Un progetto recupera le voci di chi ha vissuto questo passato in bilico tra due identità.



At the beginning of the 20th century, almost one million Italian immigrants arrived in New York City by ship. Most came from rural areas of southern Italy, [fleeing](#) poverty. They first [settled](#) in East Harlem and, after the Second World War, moved [northward](#) to the Bronx, as well as to the [borough](#) of Brooklyn and to New Jersey, on the other side of the Hudson River. Many of these Italian immigrants found work as [low-wage labour](#) at the Bronx Zoo and the Botanical Gardens, where many were employed in maintenance, construction and [landscaping](#). These workers helped shape the cultural and social fabric of the neighbourhood.

LITTLE ITALY

Today, the Bronx [boasts](#) the largest and best-preserved Little Italy neighbourhood in New York City, even though the Little Italy around Mulberry Street, in Lower Manhattan, remains the most famous. Along Arthur Avenue in the Belmont area of the Bronx, Italian shops and restaurants [line](#) the streets, some of them founded nearly a century ago, despite the fact that local economic activity has [declined](#) in recent years. The Italian American community has also been [shrinking](#): approximately seventy thousand Italian Americans now live in the [borough](#), according to the US Census Bureau, compared with well over 120,000 at its mid-20th century peak. The Italian pushcart market at Arthur and Crescent Avenues in the Bronx in 1940.

BIAHI

At Fordham University, in the Bronx, the Bronx Italian American History Initiative (BIAHI) was created in 2016. This oral history project [aims to](#) document and preserve the stories and experiences of Italian Americans through recorded interviews. At the moment, the digital archive contains around fifty interviews, with many more expected in the near future. The archive can be consulted [online](#) through the project's official website. Places

The Changing Face of Harlem: New York City Sebbene sia ancora un quartiere con alti tassi di povertà, Harlem non è più quello di una volta. Sta diventando un centro d'affari, con una fiorente offerta abitativa e una vita sociale e culturale sempre più attraente. Harlem non è più off-limits per i turisti. Lorenza Cerbini

STORIES OF IMMIGRATION

To find out more, Speak Up met with Kathleen LaPenta, the codirector of the project and senior [lecturer](#) of Italian at Fordham University at Fordham's Rose Hill campus to learn more about the initiative and the significance of Italian American immigration. LaPenta began by explaining the purpose of the archive. **Kathleen LaPenta (American accent):** In the beginning really the mission was to be able to talk to the community members of the Bronx that surrounded Fordham University where I was working and teaching, and to be able to discover what it means to be an Italian in the Bronx or from the Bronx, and how that image or that idea [unfolds](#) in personal stories and testimonies of actually living in the urban space of the Bronx in the 20th century. So I was really curious to be able to talk to people, and to be able to listen to what they had to say about being Italian or being Italian American. [Nonetheless](#) really being able to understand how the people that I was talking to think of their histories, their family histories of migration, how they [relate to](#) histories of non-Italian people migration and the

Bronx, and how they see Italy right in the present day: Have they gone to visit? Have they reconnected with [relatives](#)? Does it feel like a long-lost place to them? What is their relationship to the cultural practices like language, food, religion... How do they define everyday practices that are Italian. And their [Italian-ness](#) is often a really strongly-articulated [Italian-ness](#); very proud, very open, [in this day and age](#), it wasn't always that way... but almost as a way of marking themselves as exceptional, as sort of special within the American ethnic landscape.

INTERVIEWS

The project took inspiration from a similar initiative directed by Dr. Mark Naison, the director and founder of the Bronx African American History Project. LaPenta said the project had a generous response from the beginning. **Kathleen LaPenta:** I think we had a hundred responses on that [form](#), which is a really very high [response rate](#). So from that group, I had collected [information](#) that was really demographic [information](#) about what year were you born, what is it you want to talk about, where did you live? And so from there we started interviewing the people who had been born first, you know, the oldest people of the group that had expressed interest, that they were able to come to [the] campus. A lot of the interviews are right around the 60s and 70s, people kind of who were [coming of age](#) right in there, so I would say that mostly people born in the 40s... We have a few interviews with people born in the 20s. People born in the late 60s is about the youngest people that we've spoken to. Joe's Italian Deli, located on Arthur Avenue, is a historic, family-owned salumeria, established in 1954.

BUILDING THE BRONX

This project not only [aims to](#) promote understanding about the demographic and cultural landscape of the Bronx, but also helps to [shed light on](#) the [wider history](#) of Italian migration. For Fordham, the initiative is especially meaningful: the university has been part of the Bronx for more than a century and has evolved [alongside](#) the Italian American communities that helped shape the surrounding neighbourhoods. LaPenta [outlined](#) how Italian immigrants gradually moved into the Bronx as neighbourhoods developed and the [borough](#) urbanised, explaining that the evolution of these communities followed waves of economic expansion. **Kathleen LaPenta:** The archive itself is an interesting exercise in how the different Italian neighbourhoods have evolved in the Bronx. There is really one main commercial centre now, which is the Arthur Avenue in the Belmont neighbourhood, which is right across the street from Fordham's Rose Hill Campus, but there's also a more residential neighbourhood called Morris Park, there's also Allerton Avenue. So when you're looking at the ways in which the urban development of the Bronx took place, there's [formations](#) of small villages that then become part of the urban landscape in New York City, right in the early 20th

century. Italian immigrants, the first wave, [so to speak](#), between 1880 and 1914, they often moved into the Midtown East, which is now where the [UN](#) is. They were living in the Lower East Side or they were living in East Harlem near Our Lady of Mount Carmel Church, right at East 105th Street, I think. And so the neighbourhoods in the Bronx become a little bit more populated by many immigrant families moving up and out of Manhattan into the green Bronx, 'cause the Bronx has the most green space in New York City.

LOOKING FOR ONE'S IDENTITY

LaPenta believes that speaking with more than fifty participants has given her a deeper sense of how Italian Americans negotiate questions of identity, [belonging](#), and origins, as well as of why the Bronx remains such a powerful reference for those searching for their [roots](#). **Kathleen LaPenta:** I think it's a really interesting expression of this kind of search for identity, or search for a [background](#) that many people living in the United States — and I speak to that context because that's the context in which I live and work — we all experience that in some way. This [hyphenated identity](#) indicates that you are non-indigenous and so then you start to ask yourself this question of, “Well, where do I come from? Where are my [roots](#)?” What's really interesting is, there's very much an [attachment](#) to the Bronx as a space of immigrant identities and immigrant [formation](#) and kind of origins, and some of that I think has to do with the fact that the origins, to a certain degree, have felt like they've been lost. <https://biahi.ace.fordham.edu>

Glossary

- **boasts** = vantarsi di
- **outlined** = illustrare
- **low-wage labour** = manodopera a basso costo
- **relate to** = identificarsi con
- **response rate** = tasso di risposta
- **coming of age** = raggiungere la maggiore età
- **landscaping** = giardinaggio
- **Nonetheless** = tuttavia
- **Italian-ness** = italianità
- **in this day and age** = al giorno d'oggi
- **shed light on** = fare luce su
- **borough** = distretto, quartiere
- **alongside** = insieme a
- **UN** = ONU
- **belonging** = senso di appartenenza
- **background** = passato
- **fleeing** = fuggire
- **northward** = verso nord
- **line** = stare in fila, costeggiare
- **unfolds** = svilupparsi
- **relatives** = parenti, familiari
- **form** = formulario
- **roots** = radici, origini
- **hyphenated identity** = identità ibrida (lett. con trattino)
- **so to speak** = per così dire
- **attachment** = attaccamento, legame
- **settled** = stabilirsi
- **wider history** = contesto storico generale
- **shrinking** = diminuire
- **aims to** = avere l'obiettivo di
- **lecturer** = docente universitaria